When Both Work Full-Time:

Rethinking Gender Inequality in Household Labor

Check-in 1: Identify topic + Theory of change

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1. Topic & Motivation

Gender inequality in both unpaid household labor and paid labor outside of the home remains a central concern in the United States. Over the past several decades, women have entered the workforce in large numbers, and many families now rely on two full-time incomes. At first glance, this shift suggests progress toward equality: if both partners work similar hours, fairness at home should follow. In practice, however, the picture is more complex. Even in households where both partners work full-time, women often spend more time on domestic tasks such as cooking, cleaning, and laundry. This imbalance is not only about chores. It shapes how time and opportunity are distributed within families, and over time it can contribute to differences in career growth and economic security.

If unequal housework limits women's time for advancement in their paid work or career investment, then redistributing domestic labor could potentially reduce gender inequality beyond the home. Rather than only documenting disparities, this study seeks to examine whether a deliberate increase in men's share of household labor can shift patterns of time allocation within dual-earner households where both partners work full-time. By introducing an intervention that encourages greater male participation in unpaid labor, the project tests whether changes in domestic responsibility can reduce gender gaps in total work burden and related labor market engagement. In doing so, it evaluates whether household-level behavioral change can serve as a mechanism for promoting gender equity more broadly.

2. Research Question

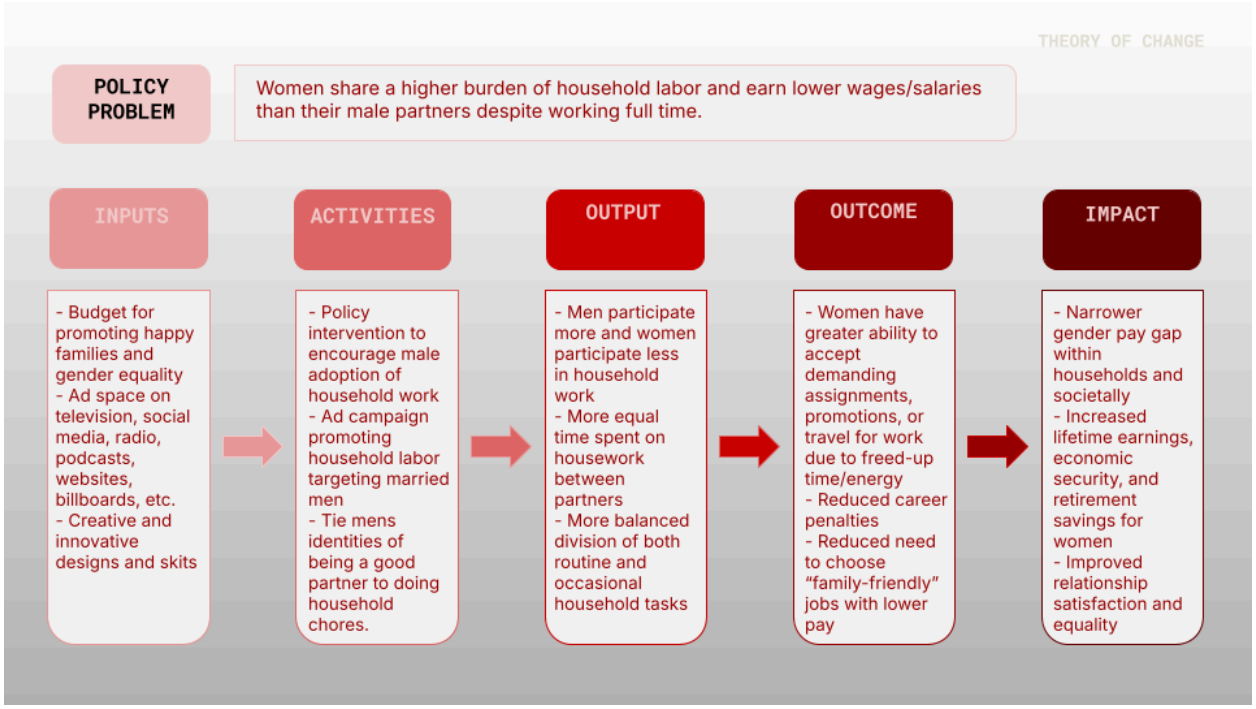
Does increasing men's share of household labor reduce the gender pay gap in dual-earner (heterosexual) households where both partners work full time?

Treatment (X): An intervention that increases men's share of unpaid household labor.

Primary Outcome (Y): Within-household gender differences paid wages.

Population: Full-time dual-earner heterosexual couples in the United States.

3. Theory of Change Diagram



4. Literature Review Scan

Prior research links gender inequality in wages and well-being to the intra-household division of unpaid labor. Beblo and Robledo (2008) develop a framework in which couples allocate time across paid work, unpaid household production, and leisure, showing that wage and leisure gaps can be jointly produced by household decision-making and specialization. This perspective suggests that unequal housework is not only an outcome of gender inequality but can also reinforce unequal time allocation across partners.

Empirical evidence connects unpaid labor to labor market outcomes. Matteazzi and Scherer (2021) show that partners' involvement in household work is closely related to the gender wage gap, with women's earnings being lower when they shoulder a larger share of unpaid tasks and more equal participation by men being associated with smaller wage gaps. Using U.S. time-diary data, Hersch (2009) similarly finds a negative association between time spent in home production and wages, consistent with the idea that domestic responsibilities can crowd out paid work time, reduce flexibility, or limit human capital accumulation.

A separate literature examines whether institutional changes can shift men's participation in unpaid labor. Petts, Carlson, and Knoester (2025) find that paternity leave-taking, especially longer leaves, is associated with fathers doing a greater share of routine housework, indicating that policies or structured interventions can move household behavior and routines in a more egalitarian direction.

Together, these studies suggest a possible causal chain central to our theory of change: interventions that increase men's share of routine housework may reduce women's "second shift," freeing time and energy for greater labor market engagement. In the longer run, changes in allocation may contribute to a smaller gender pay gap. However, existing studies often examine these links separately. Few studies directly test whether an intervention that increases men's routine housework changes within-couple time allocation in both unpaid housework and paid work, and how those shifts may relate to pay equity over the longer run. Our project addresses this gap by proposing an intervention that increases men's unpaid labor share and testing its impacts on within-household gender differences in unpaid housework time and paid work time among full-time dual-earner couples.

Citations

Beblo, M., & Robledo, J. R. (2008). The wage gap and the leisure gap for double-earner couples. *Journal of Population Economics, 21*, 281–304. https://doi.org/10.1007/s00148-006-0132-5

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Matteazzi, E., & Scherer, S. (2021). Gender wage gap and the involvement of partners in household work. *Work, Employment and Society, 35*(3), 490–508. https://doi.org/10.1177/0950017020937936

Petts, R. J., Carlson, D. L., & Knoester, C. (2025). Paternity leave-taking and US fathers' participation in housework. *Journal of Social Policy*, 1–24. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0047279425100901